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THA 231: Rudiments of Directing - Text, Space and the Six Visual Tools

Directing as preparation, composition and communication

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Directing is not shouting instructions from the back of the hall. This pack covers script analysis for directors, the six visual tools named in the department's course description, blocking and composition, rehearsal technique and the director's production paperwork.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Analyse a script for given circumstances, spine and directorial concept.
- Apply the six visual tools: ground plan, composition, picturisation, movement, rhythm and pantomimic dramatisation.
- Block a scene for clarity and emphasis.
- Run a rehearsal with a clear plan and give usable notes.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Script analysis for directors

You cannot stage what you have not understood.

- Given circumstances: time, place, society, relationships and prior events.
- Spine: the through-line of action that holds the production together.
- Units and beats: divide the scene into playable sections.
- Character objectives and obstacles, scene by scene.
- Theme: the argument the production will make visible.

- Design requirements implied by the text.

The six visual tools

These are the department's named tools; know them by name and use.

- Ground plan: the spatial arrangement of set, entrances and furniture.
- Composition: where bodies sit in the frame of the stage or camera.
- Picturisation: composing stage pictures that tell the story.
- Movement: planned and motivated physical action across the space.
- Rhythm: pace, pause and tempo changes that shape tension.
- Pantomimic dramatisation: telling story through physical action without words.

> **Directing is choosing**
> A production without choices becomes a reading. Decide what the audience should notice in each beat, then use the tools to make them notice it.

Rehearsal and notes

Rehearsal technique is a professional skill in its own right.

- Plan each rehearsal with a goal, a sequence and a stopping point.
- Start with table work before blocking if the text is dense.
- Give notes that are specific, playable and few.
- Never give a note that contradicts the actor's objective without explanation.
- Rehearse transitions, entrances and exits as rigorously as dialogue.
- Keep a prompt script with blocking and cues.

Directing is decided in advance

The common image of a director is someone shouting instructions. In practice, directing is mostly preparation: reading the script until you can say what it is about in one sentence, deciding what the audience must feel at each turn, and then building a plan that produces those effects. Rehearsal is where the plan meets the actors, not where the plan is invented.

Start with the through-line: whose story is it, what do they want, and what does the play do to them? Then choose a spine for the production - an interpretation that gives every scene a purpose. A production without a spine is a collection of well-acted scenes that do not add up.

The six visual tools are the director's compositional vocabulary: level, balance, contrast, focus, rhythm and proportion. They are taught because they are checkable. Before you tell an actor to move, ask which tool the move is serving. If none, the move is decoration.

The six visual tools in use

Level refers to height relationships: a standing figure against a seated one creates authority before a word is spoken. Balance is the distribution of visual weight across the stage; an unbalanced composition produces unease, which is useful when the scene is unstable and distracting when it is not. Contrast is difference - in costume, light, sound, tempo - and is how the audience is told what matters.

Focus is where attention goes, and it is created by light, movement, stillness, and the direction of other actors' gazes. Rhythm is the pattern of duration and pause in a scene: a director who lets every scene run at the same speed has no rhythm. Proportion is the relative size and prominence of elements, including how much of the stage each actor occupies.

Use the tools to solve problems rather than to decorate. If the audience is watching the wrong character, change focus rather than telling the actor to be louder. If a scene feels flat, change rhythm before changing the text.

> **The blocking notebook**
> Record every blocking choice with the reason: "cross down left - so the letter is hidden from the audience until she turns". When you cannot write a reason, you have found a move to cut.

Working with actors, and rehearsal structure

Actors need three things from a director: clarity about what the scene must achieve, freedom in how to achieve it, and consistency. Give notes that describe the effect rather than the feeling ("the audience must not know whether you are lying") and let the actor find the behaviour. Never give a line reading unless the actor asks; it produces imitation instead of performance.

A workable rehearsal sequence: table work to establish the story and the characters' objectives, blocking to fix the physical shape, then detailed work on beats and transitions, then runs with technical elements, then dress rehearsals. Compress according to time available, but never skip the table work entirely - it is cheaper to fix a misunderstanding before anyone has learned a movement.

Notes after a run should be few, specific and ordered by importance. Three clear notes acted on beat twenty scattered observations. Always say what worked, because actors need to know what to keep as much as what to change.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 231

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- The 2018 page describes the director and the six visual tools: ground plan, composition, picturisation, movement, rhythm and pantomimic dramatisation
- Play analysis and communication of meaning to varied audiences
- Emphasis on proscenium dominance, model making and performance space configuration

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 231 Rudiments of Directing, 3 credits, first semester, 200 level
- THA 322 Script Analysis and Interpretation for Performance follows at 300 level
- THA 433 Studies in Technical Directing appears at 400 level

What changed: The 2019 listing gives directing a three-step ladder (231, 322, 433) rather than a single described course.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Rudiments of directing remains the 200-level directing core
- The six visual tools are still the named framework to use in answers
- Confirm whether your directing assessment includes a staged scene or a written prompt book

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Blocking a scene for a specific effect

A two-hander where one character must feel trapped and the other in control - with no furniture available.

1. Choose the level relationship: the controlling character stands; the trapped one begins seated on the floor, then rises late.
2. Set the focus: the controlling character always faces the audience side of the trapped one, so we see the trapped face react.
3. Create contrast: give the controlling character almost no movement and the trapped one a small repeated gesture.
4. Use proportion: keep the trapped character downstage, close to the audience, isolated on one third of the stage.
5. Control rhythm: long silences in the first half, accelerating crossings in the second.
6. Test with a spectator: ask who they watched and when, then adjust focus only.

> **What to carry forward**
> Compose the relationship, not the picture. The tools exist to make power visible.

2. Giving a note that works

An actor delivers a confession scene at full emotional intensity from the first line. Fix it.

1. Describe the problem as an effect, not a judgement: "we know too early, so we stop listening".
2. State the requirement: the audience must suspect before they are certain.
3. Offer a playable action: "try to keep it from him for as long as you can".
4. Give them a second attempt without further explanation.
5. Note what changed and name it, so the actor knows what to repeat.

> **What to carry forward**
> Notes should give the actor a task, not a diagnosis of their talent.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Discuss the director's responsibility for the through-line of a production.

20 marks

1. Define through-line and distinguish it from theme.
2. Explain how it guides casting, cutting, blocking and pace.
3. Show what happens without one: episodic production, unclear stakes.
4. Acknowledge the collaborative limit: designers and actors contribute to the spine.
5. Conclude that the through-line is an argument the director must be able to state.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Confusing a theme (what the play is about) with a through-line (what the production is doing with it).

Q2. Explain three of the six visual tools and give a staging problem each solves.

15 marks

1. Name the tools and define them.
2. For each, give a concrete staging problem and the compositional fix.
3. Explain the principle that tools solve problems rather than decorate.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Through-line. The organising action of a production that gives every scene a purpose.

Spine. The director's stated interpretation that unifies decisions.

Blocking. The planned movement and positioning of actors in space.

Level. Height relationships between performers, used to show authority and vulnerability.

Balance. The distribution of visual weight across the stage picture.

Contrast. Deliberate difference in light, costume, tempo or sound that marks significance.

Focus. The direction of audience attention, created by light, movement and gaze.

Rhythm. The pattern of duration, pause and tempo across a scene or production.

Proportion. The relative size and prominence of elements on stage.

Table work. Rehearsal discussion of text, objectives and story before staging.

Note. A director's specific instruction given after a rehearsal or run.

Technical rehearsal. A rehearsal integrating light, sound, scene changes and cues with the acting.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Read

The play on paper.

- Write the one-sentence spine.
- Mark every scene's turning point.
- List what the audience must know and when.

Week 2 - Compose

Visual tools.

- Draw a ground plan.
- Block one scene using three tools.
- Justify every move in writing.

Week 3 - Rehearse

Working with actors.

- Run table work on act one.
- Give notes as playable actions.
- Record one note and its effect.

Week 4 - Run

Integration.

- Run with cues.
- Cut one move that has no reason.
- Write a three-note page for the company.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any directing handbook covering composition, blocking and rehearsal structure.
- A director's published rehearsal notes or interview about a specific production.
- Your department's technical facilities list so your plan is buildable.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name the six visual tools of directing.

Answer: Ground plan, composition, picturisation, movement, rhythm and pantomimic dramatisation.

2. What are given circumstances?

Answer: The established conditions of the play - time, place, society, relationships and prior events - that shape character action.

3. Why must notes be playable?

Answer: An actor can act an action such as 'make him leave' but cannot act an abstraction such as 'be more intense'.

4. How does rhythm affect a scene?

Answer: Variation in pace, pause and tempo controls tension, emphasis and the audience's attention.

5. What belongs in a prompt script?

Answer: Blocking, cue calls, scene changes and notes for technical departments.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Analyse a short scene into units and beats.
- [ ] Write a one-page directorial concept.
- [ ] Draw a ground plan for your scene.
- [ ] Block two pages and rehearse them with actors.
- [ ] Practise giving three playable notes.
- [ ] Time a run-through and adjust the rhythm.
- [ ] Review a recorded scene and identify two composition errors.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: